

Balaenoptera physalus

Fin whale



Length 72–89 ft (22–27 m)
Weight 59–89½ tons (60–90 tonnes)
Social unit Variable
Status Endangered

Location Worldwide (except E. Mediterranean, Baltic, Red Sea, Arabian Gulf)



The fin whale is the second-largest whale, and one of the fastest. In addition to some hums and squeals, it produces an immensely loud, deep moan that can be heard hundreds of miles away. Like other great whales, the fin whale undertakes long

migrations from high latitudes in summer, where it feeds on fish and krill, toward tropical regions for winter and breeding. The gestation period is 11 months, the newborn calf 21 ft (6.4 m) long, and weaning takes place at 9–10 months. This means each female has only one offspring every 2 years, so low populations take decades to recover.

FIN, FLIPPERS, AND FLUKES

The fin whale's back, flippers, and flukes are gray. The dorsal fin, set two-thirds of the way along the back, has a concave rear edge.



RIGHT-SIDED FEEDING

Fin whales carry out high-speed lunge-feeding, on krill and fish such as capelin or herring. The whales synchronize attacks and take in huge volumes of water, close the mouth, and force out the water to trap fish on the baleen. The whale swims on its right side, which may be why the left part of the mouth is black but the right is white. Such asymmetry in color is very unusual in mammals.



Balaenoptera musculus

Blue whale



Length 104–107 ft (31.7–32.6 m)
Weight 111½–113½ tons (113–115 tonnes)
Social unit Individual
Status Endangered

Location Worldwide (except Mediterranean, Baltic, Red Sea, Arabian Gulf)



The biggest animal on the planet, the blue whale can consume more than 6⅝ tons (6 tonnes) of small euphausiid crustaceans, of which its diet almost exclusively consists. It lunges into a

school of prey and its throat swells to 4 times the normal width. It closes its mouth, expels the water, and swallows the thousands of food items retained by the baleen. Feeding occurs mainly in summer, in and near rich polar waters. The blue whale is thought to migrate to warmer, lower latitudes for winter, when the females give birth. The calf is 23 ft (7 m) long, 2¾ tons (2.5 tonnes) in weight, and is suckled for 6–8 months. Blue whales are usually solitary or in mother-calf pairs, although they may gather as loose groups to feed. They make grunts, hums, and moans, which at volumes greater than 180 decibels are the loudest of any creature sounds.

ANATOMY OF A DIVE



When making a deep dive, the whale “headstands,” exposing its distinctively wide tail flukes, then descends steeply to a maximum depth of some 655 ft (200 m). The long, narrow flippers play no part in propulsion, the thrust coming from the powerful back muscles that swish the rear body and flukes up and down.

Balaenoptera omurai

Omura's whale



Length 32¾–39¼ in (10–12 m)
Weight 22 tons (20 tonnes)
Social Not known
Status Data deficient

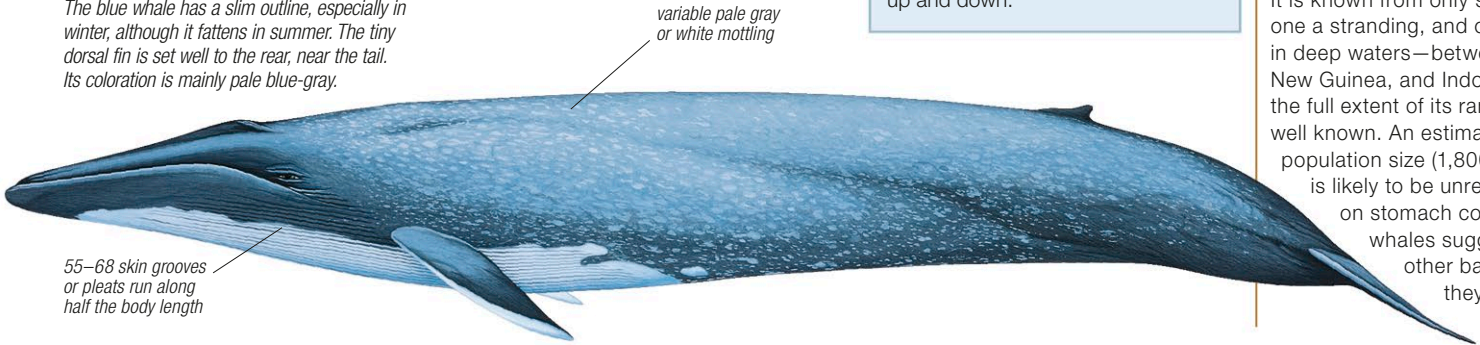
Location Pacific Ocean



Previously considered a pygmy form of Bryde's whale, this new species was recognized by Japanese researchers from studies of material collected by sresearch whaling ships in the Pacific in the 1970s and 1990s, and was subsequently determined to be a more primitive baleen lineage. It is known from only 9 specimens—one a stranding, and others caught in deep waters—between Japan, New Guinea, and Indonesia, but the full extent of its range is not yet well known. An estimate of global population size (1,800 individuals) is likely to be unreliable. Studies on stomach contents of these whales suggest that—like other baleen whales—they feed primarily on krill.

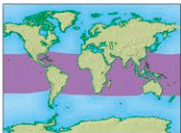
STREAMLINED GIANT

The blue whale has a slim outline, especially in winter, although it fattens in summer. The tiny dorsal fin is set well to the rear, near the tail. Its coloration is mainly pale blue-gray.



Balaenoptera edeni

Bryde's whale



Length 42½–47½ ft (13–14.5 m)
Weight 15–16 tons (15–16 tonnes)
Social unit Variable
Status Data deficient

Location Tropical and warm temperate waters worldwide



Bryde's (pronounced “Broodah's”), Bryde's whale is mainly coastal in the Eastern Indian and West Pacific oceans. The larger, more offshore subspecies Bryde's whale is found in the Atlantic and Indian oceans, and parts of the North, East, and South Pacific. Apart from their size difference, both subspecies have blue-gray coloration that is paler on the underside, 40–70

throat grooves, coarse-bristled baleen plates, and a small dorsal fin set two-thirds of the way along the stocky body. These whales dive for up to 20 minutes to feed mainly on schooling fish and krill. They usually live alone or in small, loose herds, but may gather in dozens where prey is plentiful. Both subspecies of Bryde's whale are rapid

swimmers, changing speed and direction frequently. They surface steeply to reveal the head first, arch over, and expose the rear of the body but not the tail flukes as they dive. The female reaches sexual maturity at 8–11 years and produces a single calf after a gestation of 11–12 months.

